

Language Endangerment in the Caucasus

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Abstract

Though less threatened with extinction than languages of some other parts of the world, the languages of the Caucasus present a number of opportunities to examine language endangerment through a unique sociolinguistic and typological lens. The following paper will survey the state of such endangered languages: how many languages there are, what kinds of language ecologies form their social milieu, and the kinds, rates and causes of language shift in the region. It will also survey the role of language contact in the region, including how processes of multilingualism, borrowing and structural convergence and code-switching operate in situations of language maintenance, substrate, adstrate and obsolescence effects. It will examine some of the unique structural aspects of endangered languages in the Caucasus, including typological *rara* and look at how some of these features change: over/under-generalization of marked features, gain/loss of phonological and morphosyntactic contrasts, as well as over-all typological shift.

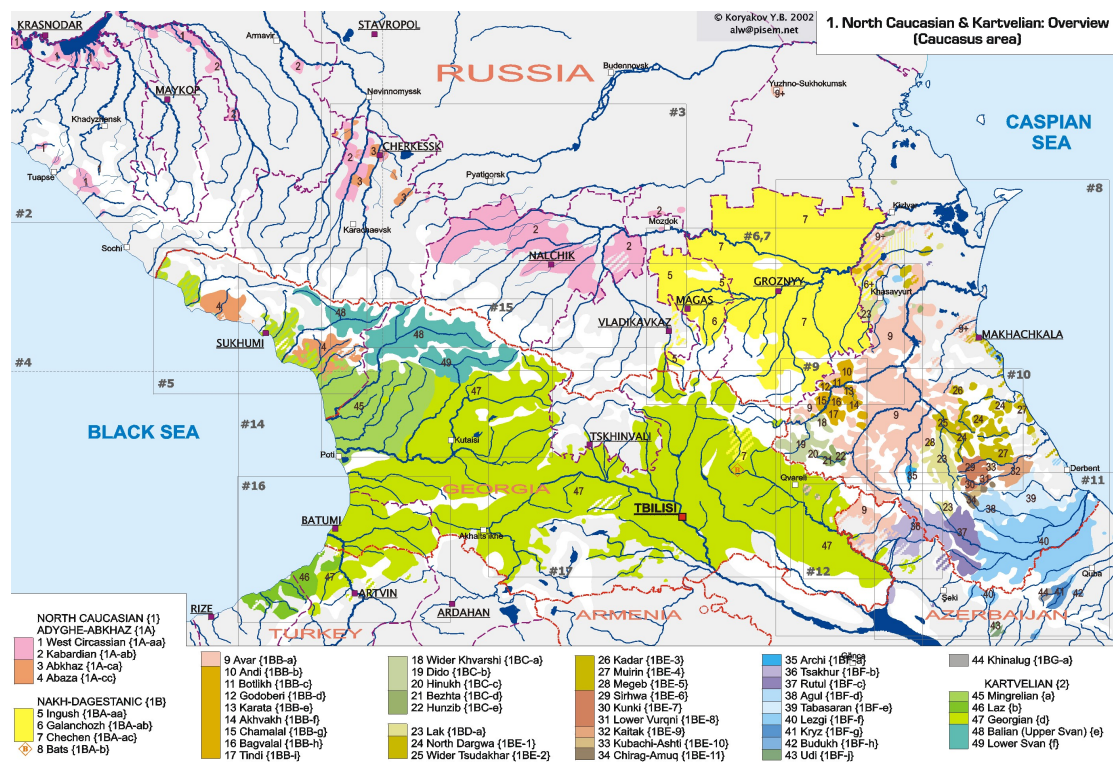
The Caucasus sits as a kind fulcrum of Eurasia, around which many of the most important centers of human civilization and culture have arisen. Because of this, over millennia its peoples and languages have interacted on all sides with numerous other outside ethnolinguistic groups, which in time often came to settle there and enrich it further. But it is not just its macrogeographical place within Eurasia that has shaped it: its linguistic diversity has also been shaped by the specific features of its internal topography and natural resources. Its mountainous, contoured terrain has both directed and constrained which communities could interact with which other communities, leading in the *longue durée* of premodern linguistic history to a classical residual zone (Nichols 1992, 1997) in which linguistic diversity has tended only to increase and not decrease. Modernity on the other hand has challenged this in every way, with its processes of technological globalization and colonialism that pose potential threats to long-established life-ways. In this paper, I would like to examine how these forces are affecting the region's linguistic diversity today and what consequences they have for its peoples and for linguists who study the region, and an understanding of linguistic typology and language endangerment generally.

§1 Ecology of language diversity and endangerment in the Caucasus

What is a Caucasian language? It is a provocative question, but a necessary one to address. Because the Caucasus forms a peninsula between the plains of north-central Europe and the mountains and plateaus of Anatolia and Iran, with discrete boundaries only on the Black Sea to the west and the Caspian Sea to the east, different scholars have included different languages and language families in their discussion of the Caucasus. All works have included at least three core 'autochthonous' families of Abkhaz-Adyghean, Kartvelian and Nakh-Daghestanian, so-called because they have no uncontroversial connections to any language family outside the region (nor, in the opinion of most scholars, to each other). In addition, most scholars include members of three other language families of long standing: Indo-European (Indo-Iranian, Armenian and Balto-Slavic), Altaic (Turkic, Mongolic), and Afro-Asiatic (Semitic).

1.1 Extent of Diversity and Endangerment in the Caucasus

Within this region today we can count something like eighty different indigenous languages. This number includes all languages in the region that are currently being acquired by children, as well as all languages that are or have recently been a norm in their individual communities, even if they are no longer being actively acquired by children or indeed are not spoken at all. It thus includes languages like **Ubykh**, which has only recently become extinct; **Batsbi** (Tsova-Tush), which is still spoken by adults above the age of about 40, but is not currently being acquired by children; and **Azerbaijani Sign Language**, used by the hearing-impaired community of Azerbaijan. On the other hand, it excludes a language like English which has very recently become ubiquitous as a second regional *lingua franca*, spoken to some degree by perhaps 10-20% of the region's population, but which has not achieved a settled, established position. It also excludes lects like **Khevsur** and **Tush**, highly divergent forms of Georgian with only limited mutual intelligibility with the standard language, but which are not considered sufficiently distinct by either community members or scholars to constitute separate languages. It further does not include chronolects like **Old Georgian** or **Caucasian Albanian**¹ which evolved into modern forms still spoken today, nor languages which in the distant past had or probably had important sociolinguistic roles, including Arabic, Persian and Urartian.



Map 1. Languages of the Caucasus

¹ Not to be confused with the entirely unrelated Albanian language of the Balkans, of Indo-European origin.

Table 1. Languages of the Caucasus, with speaker numbers and status.

Language	Phylum	No. L1 Speakers	Source	Vitality
Abaza	Abkhaz-Adyghean; Abkhaz-Abaza	36,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	5 - Developing
Abaza, Tapanta	Abkhaz-Adyghean; Abkhaz-Abaza	15,000	John Colarusso, p.c.	6b – Threatened
Abkhaz	Abkhaz-Adyghean; Abkhaz-Abaza	124,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Adyghe	Abkhaz-Adyghean; Circassian	115,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	2 - Provincial
Agul	Nakh-Daghestanian; Lezgian	27,000–29,300	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6a - Vigorous
Akhvakh, Northern	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	9500	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Akhvakh, Southern	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	8000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Andi	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	22,500	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Andi, Muni-Kwakhidatl	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	4000	Koryakov et al. 2022	6b – Threatened
Archi	Nakh-Daghestanian; Lezgian	970–1500	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Armenian, Eastern	Indo-European; Armenian	3,800,000 in all countries	Ethnologue 2022	1 – National
Armenian, Western	Indo-European; Armenian	1,600,000 in all countries	Ethnologue 2022	5 - Developing
Avar	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	693,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	3 – Wider Communication
Azerbaijani	Altaic; Turkic	9,000,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	1 – National
Bagvalal	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	1500–5500	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Batsbi	Nakh-Daghestanian; Nakh	500	Dobrushina et al. 2021	7 – Shifting
Bezhta	Nakh-Daghestanian; Tsezic	6500–6800	Dobrushina et al. 2021	5 – Developing
Bohtan Neo-Aramaic	Afro-Asiatic; Semitic	500–900	Fox 2019; Ethnologue 2022	7 – Shifting
Botlikh	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	210–7400	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Budukh	Nakh-Daghestanian; Lezgian	200	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Chamalal	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	9600	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Chamalal, Hihatli	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	1600	Koryakov et al. 2022	6b – Threatened
Chechen	Nakh-Daghestanian; Nakh	1,300,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	2 – Provincial
Dargwa, Amuzgi-Shiri	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	200–400	Dobrushina et al. 2021	7 – Shifting
Dargwa, Chirag	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	2000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Dargwa, Gapshima	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	2300	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Dargwa, Kaitag	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	23,600	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Dargwa, Kubachi-Ashti	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	6200	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Dargwa, Mehweb	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	800	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Dargwa, Muira	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	34,500	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6a – Vigorous
Dargwa, Northern	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	133,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	4 – Educational
Dargwa, Sanzhi-Itsari	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	2000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Dargwa, Shari	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	1200	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Dargwa, Tanti	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	13,700	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Dargwa, Tsudaqar	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	30,500	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Dargwa, Usisha-Butri	Nakh-Daghestanian; Dargic	7,600	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Domari	Indo-European; Indo-Iranian	280,670 across all regions	Ethnologue 2022	6b – Threatened
Georgian	Kartvelian; Georgian-Zan	3,380,000	Ethnologue 2022	1 – National
Godoberi	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	3200	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Greek, Cappadocian	Indo-European; Hellenic	‘a few in Georgia’	Dobrushina et al. 2021	8a – Moribund
Greek, Pontic	Indo-European; Hellenic	30,000–40,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	7 – Shifting
Hinukh	Nakh-Daghestanian; Tsezic	450	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Hunzib	Nakh-Daghestanian; Tsezic	1000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Ingush	Nakh-Daghestanian; Nakh	293,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	2 – Provincial
Kabardian	Abkhaz-Adyghean; Circassian	505,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	5 – Developing
Karachay-Balkar	Altaic; Turkic	299,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	5 – Developing
Karata	Nakh-Daghestanian; Avar-Andic	11,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Khinalug	Nakh-Daghestanian; Khinalug	2200	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Khwarshi	Nakh-Daghestanian; Tsezic	2200	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Khwarshi, Inkhwari	Nakh-Daghestanian; Tsezic	1000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Kryz	Nakh-Daghestanian; Lezgian	4400	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Kumyk	Altaic; Turkic	403,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	5 – Developing
Kurdish, Northern	Indo-European; Indo-Iranian	60,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Lak	Nakh-Daghestanian; Lak	140,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	4 - Educational
Laz	Kartvelian; Zan	22,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Lezgian	Nakh-Daghestanian; Lezgian	546,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	5 – Developing
Lomavren	Mixed Language	50	Ethnologue 2015	8a - Moribund
Megrelian	Kartvelian; Zan	300,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6a - Vigorous

Noghai	Altaic; Turkic	73,000-87,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Ossetic, Iron	Indo-European; Indo-Iranian	500,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	2 - Provincial
Ossetic, Digor	Indo-European; Indo-Iranian	up to 100,000	Comrie 1984	6b – Threatened
Romani	Indo-European; Indo-Iranian	34,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Russian	Indo-European; Balto-Slavic	8.3m-8.5m L1 in region	Dobrushina et al. 2021	0 - International
Rutul	Nakh-Daghestanian; Lezgitic	27,300	Dobrushina et al. 2021	5 – Developing
Sign-Language, Armenian	French Sign Language family	3150	Ethnologue 2022	Unestablished
Sign-Language, Azerbaijani	French Sign Language family	3457-4800	M.Zaslansky, p.c.	Unestablished
Sign-Language, Georgian	French Sign Language family	2500	Makharoblidze2012	Unestablished
Sign-Language, Russian	French Sign Language family	~700,000 in all countries	Ethnologue 2022	Unestablished
Svan	Kartvelian; Svan	35,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	7 - Shifting
Tabasaran	Nakh-Daghestanian; Lezgitic	117,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	5 – Developing
Talysh	Indo-European; Indo-Iranian	77,400	Dobrushina et al. 2021	4 - Educational
Tat	Indo-European; Indo-Iranian	33,000	Ethnologue 2022	6b – Threatened
Tat, Judeo-	Indo-European; Indo-Iranian	up to 101,000	Ethnologue 2015	6b – Threatened
Tat, Shirvan	Indo-European; Indo-Iranian			
Tindi	Nakh-Daghestanian;Avar-Andic	9,300	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Tsakhur	Nakh-Daghestanian; Lezgitic	up to 20,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Tsez	Nakh-Daghestanian; Tsezic	12,300	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Tsez, Sagada	Nakh-Daghestanian; Tsezic	700	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Tukita	Nakh-Daghestanian;Avar-Andic	1300	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Turkish, Meskhetian	Altaic; Turkic	85,000	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6a - Vigorous
Ubykh	Abkhaz-Adyghean; Ubykh	0	Fenwick 2011	10 - Extinct
Udi	Nakh-Daghestanian; Lezgitic	4900	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Ukrainian	Indo-European; Balto-Slavic	110,000 in region	Dobrushina et al. 2021	1 – National
Urmian Jewish Neo-Aramaic	Afro-Asiatic; Semitic	500	Dobrushina et al. 2021	6b – Threatened
Urum	Altaic; Turkic	190,000 in all countries	Ethnologue 2015	6b – Threatened

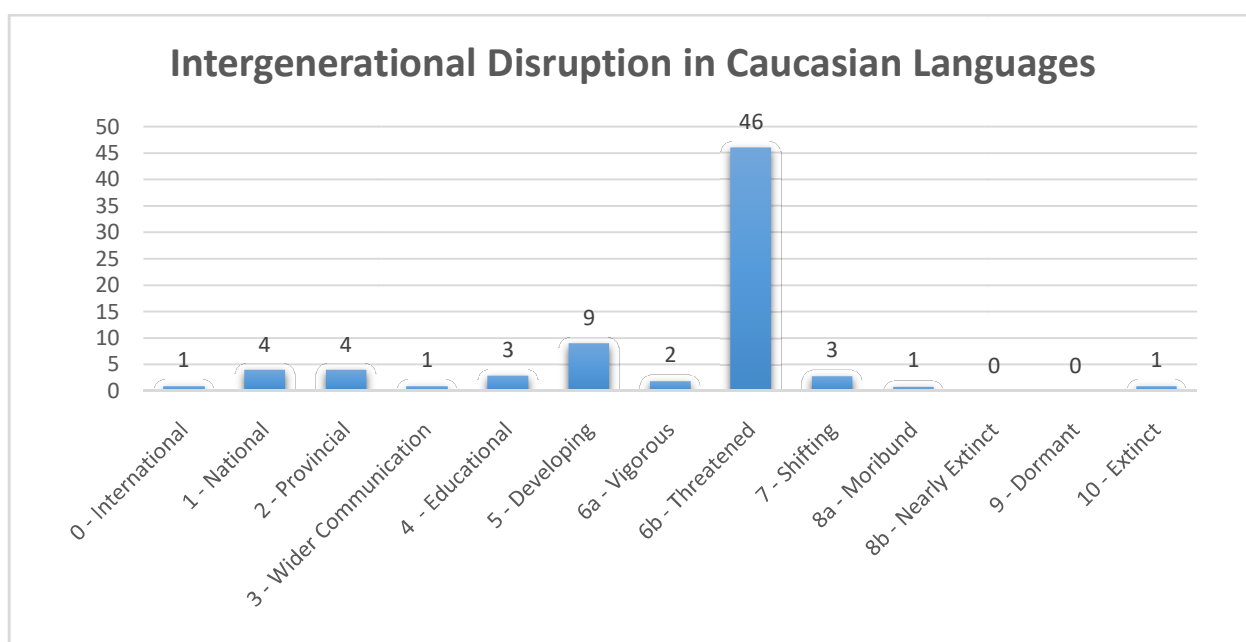


Table 2. EGIDS Intergenerational disruption scale: 0 – international languages with large speaker bases and widely used between nations for trade, knowledge exchange and international policy; 1 – national languages used in education, work, mass media and government; 2 – provincial languages used in education, mass media and government in a national subdivision; 3 – languages without official status but nonetheless used in mass media to transcend differences across the region; 4 – educational languages in vigorous use, with standardized literature and used in institutional settings; 5 – developing languages in vigorous use with standardized literature but not yet widespread or sustainable; 6a – vigorous languages used for face-to-face communication by all generations and sustainable; 6b – threatened languages used for face-to-face communication but losing speakers; 7 – shifting languages whose child-bearing generation uses the language but whose children are not acquiring the language; 8a – moribund languages whose only active users are the grandparent generation or older; 8b – nearly extinct languages only of grandparent generation with little opportunity to use the language; 9 – dormant languages serving as reminder of heritage identity but no one has more than symbolic proficiency; 10 – extinct languages no longer used and which no longer serve as marker of identity (Ethnologue 2022)



Map 2: Endangered Languages of the Caucasus according to the EGIDS scale (Ethnologue 2022)

The distribution of languages within the region is quite uneven, with the greatest density of languages found in the northern and eastern highlands and piedmont of Daghestan. Languages of the region also exhibit a wide range of population sizes and statuses (as in **Table 1**). A few languages like **Azerbaijani**, **Russian**, **Georgian**, **Armenian** and **Chechen** bear robust population sizes, with a million or more speakers, while most languages are spoken by twenty

thousand people or less. Especially in the Russian Federation, some languages have a special protected or official provincial status: **Chechen**,

Ingush, **Northern Dargwa**, **Lak** and **Iron Ossetic** fall into this category. Many languages, especially in southern Daghestan and the south Caucasian republics are still being acquired by children, but literacy and education in the language hardly exists: **Megrelian**, **Rutul** and **Tabasaran**, for example. In still relatively few languages, language shift to another language has begun and few or no children are acquiring the language; **Svan** is perhaps the largest and most significant case. In all cases, sheer population size alone cannot be taken as a direct indicator of linguistic vitality. **Adyghe** and **Abkhaz** both have slightly more than one hundred thousand speakers, and yet while Adyghe is being widely used as a provincial language in public spaces and being passed onto future generations (2 on the EGIDS scale), Abkhaz is less clearly secure, despite its status as the official language of a *de facto* state, because the sociolinguistic milieu of Abkhazia favors the use of Russian in an increasing number of domains; it is ranked as 6b ‘threatened’ on the same scale.

In the same way, different phylogenetic (sub)families may also undergo differing levels of endangerment (see **Table 3**). This not only reflects widely divergent political and institutional environments across the region, but also long-term patterns of migration, contact and identity. Thus while the Andic family and the Lezgian family have similar levels of internal linguistic diversity in terms of the over-all number of languages, the Andic languages are considerably more threatened with speaker loss than the more southerly Lezgian languages. Speakers of Andic languages have historically used **Avar** as a local lingua franca, and in historical records are even sometimes ethnically described as subclasses of Avars. Such a situation does not hold in southern Daghestan, where the prominence of Lezgian had been less all-encompassing, and where a competing lingua franca, Azerbaijani, had long made acquisition of a local interlanguage less straight-forward. In the case of Dargwa, a family of at least thirteen languages with about as much linguistic diversity as the entire Germanic language family, speakers identify ethnically as Dargwa and language shift is largely in the direction of the in-group Northern Dargwa macrolanguage. Thus ethnic identity is sometimes, but not always, congruent with the language of contact.

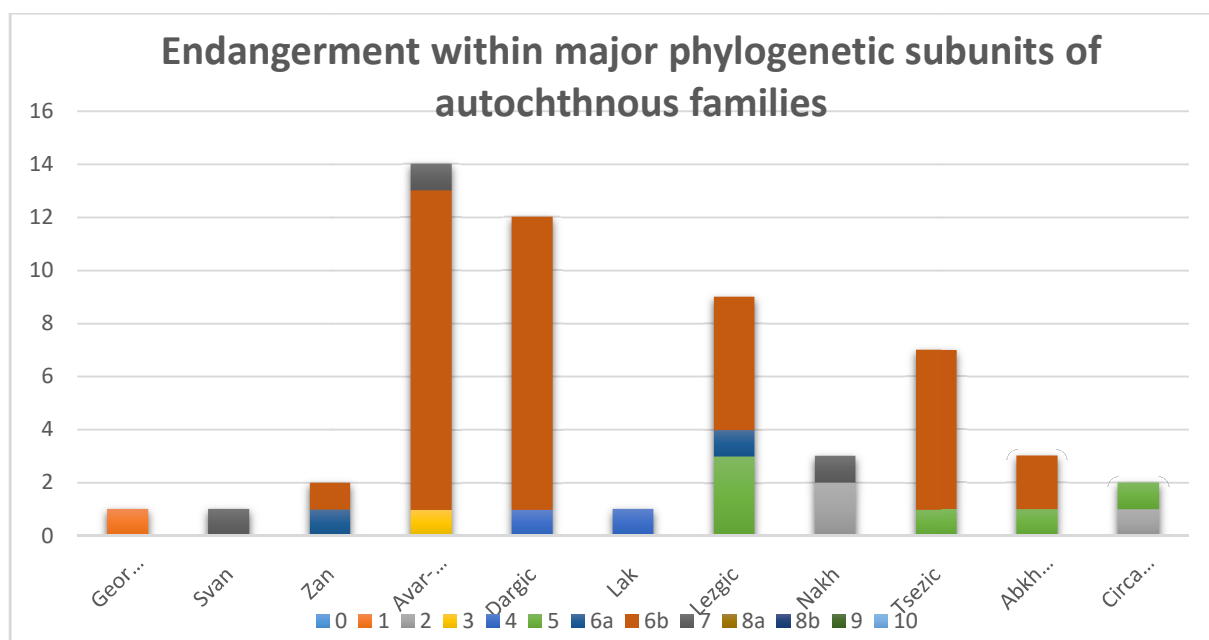


Table 3. Differential endangerment of different phylogenetic units

1.2 Modes of language shift

Because of its long written history and deep archaeological record, much more is known about the history of language shift in the Caucasus than most other zones of high linguistic diversity, starting with Urartian in the seventh century BCE. In some cases, rapid shifts in the speakers' environment have undermined the demographic basis or internal structure of their communities, whether through epidemic disease, warfare or natural disasters. In February 1944, Soviet authorities deported at least 496,000 ethnic Chechens and Ingush *en masse* to Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan, leading to many tens of thousands of deaths and the total dislocation and rearrangement of their communities upon their return in 1957 (XX). In 1987, extremely heavy snowfall produced a disastrous series of avalanches in the Svaneti region of Georgia, leading to the resettlement of around 16,000 mostly Svan speakers into southeastern Georgia where the Svan language was formerly unknown (Bordokoff 2014). Only a few years later, in 1992-1993, civil war erupted in neighboring Abkhazia between Abkhaz and mostly Megrelian-speaking ethnic Georgians, leading to ethnic cleansing and a refugee crisis in which a quarter million Megrelians were forced to flee to other parts of Georgia where Megrelian was not spoken (XX). Though the three situations had very different ultimate causes, they had similar outcomes for the acquisition of their respective languages by subsequent generations of displaced community members, since younger displaced Chechens, Ingush, Svans and Megrelians faced a completely different sociolinguistic context that was conducive to rapid language shift towards other forms of language. As a result, Svan and Megrelian are faced with losing between a quarter and a third of their native speakers within one generation, and the **Galanch'ozh** variety of Nakh (intermediary between Chechen and Ingush and sometimes considered a separate language) has almost completely disappeared.

More frequently, language shift occurs gradually, and this is partly due to the physical topography of the land and how it constrains human cultural and economic interactions. The geography of the Caucasus is not uniformly mountainous. On the south face of the Greater Caucasus, the mountains tend to form a sheer wall some 3000 to 5000 meters high which meet wide plains such as the Rioni or Kura-Araxes river basins. On the north face, on the other hand, the topography consists of numerous deeply cut river valleys, sometimes 2000 or more meters deep, which cut off even nearby communities from each other. For this reason alone, the topography itself creates different levels of diversity in different microregions, north versus south. But this topography and its accompanying (micro)climates also shape the kinds of economies that can be sustained in different areas. Because the highlands of Daghestan have poor soil and low levels of precipitation, intensive agriculture is in most places hardly possible, and communities traditionally subsisted on pastoral economies rearing cattle, sheep and other livestock. In the very highest regions, however, even this becomes seasonally impossible, which leads to annual migrations of herders to lower more fertile elevations. This then has a knock-on effect for extremely long-term patterns of language contact and language shift, which Wixman (Wixman 1980) calls the ‘vertical zone’ principle and which Nichols (1992) calls ‘vertical polylingualism’: pastoral communities of higher elevations learn all the languages of communities at lower elevations, while the inverse has not been true. As Wixman describes it:

“These languages [of the lowlands – TRW] became dominant since it was in the lowland areas where the mountaineers brought their stock to winter pastures, where the landless mountaineers found jobs, working either in the cities or as the ‘migrant farmers’ and where the major trading centers were located. Similarly, the peoples of the lower elevations were dominant in terms of assimilation processes. In this way, many of the highlanders were being both linguistically and ethnically assimilated by the peoples at the lower levels.” (Wixman 1980: 108)

Thus along the Samur river valley, the highland **Tsakhur** pastoral communities would migrate first through **Rutul** communities before coming to market in Lezgian speaking regions, who in turn would often interact with Azerbaijanis and Russians in the larger cities, in each case picking one or more of the languages spoken there. It is likely that this pattern of language contact and (eventual) language replacement is age-old, and occurred in periods long before its attestation in the first written texts. Phylogenetic analysis suggests that while Rutul and Tsakhur belong on the same subbranch, the more elevated Archi community and the lower Lezgi communities belong to completely different subbranches, with Archi being an extreme early-diverging outlier within Lezgic, and **Lezgi** itself occupying a more central, later position in the cladistic tree. This geolinguistic distribution is compatible with a very early migration of proto-Archi speakers up the Samur valley, followed by a later replacement of Proto-Rutul-Tsakhur speakers, who in turn were later replaced in the lower reaches by Lezgi speakers. Thus language attrition need not reflect conscious, active policy-making on the part of any one political regime or authority; it may be a reflection of extremely long-term patterns of how humans interact with each other and with their environment.

In other cases, language policy and linguistic ideology have indeed been important factors affecting language use. One medieval Georgian text defines Georgia as ‘anywhere where the mass is said in the Georgian language’ (Rayfield 2013: 7), and the hegemonic role this liturgical language had may have contributed to the lack of documentation of other regional varieties of Kartvelian languages until the late eighteenth century. In more recent times, the Russian Empire and its successor the Soviet Union both implemented language policies affecting the use of Caucasian languages. As Blauvelt and Vacharadze note, in the late, more reactionary Russian Empire, ‘while curtailing native language literacy was never a goal or priority in itself, it became a consequence of the desire for administrative uniformity’ (Blauvelt & Vacharadze 2017: 17). The Soviet Union early on openly embraced a program of *korenizatsiya* (‘indigenization’) in which the titular languages of union republics and some of the larger languages would be used as vehicles in primary education and the bureaucracy to better recruit local Communist Party cadres (see Blauvelt 2020 for discussion). In practice, this often came at the expense of the smallest language communities, who were forced to adopt a larger regional language as a local *lingua franca* even when that language had not functioned as such or in precisely the same way before. A case in point is Abkhaz, which between 1921 and 1931 constituted the smallest union republic. After its incorporation into the Georgian SSR under the auspices of Lavrenti Beria, a program of Georgianization began which sought to reduce the Abkhaz language to a distinctly subordinate role:

“[As a result of the *korenizatsiya* policy] not only were the official statuses of the Georgian and Armenian languages enshrined in their respective Soviet constitutions of 1937 and the use of their historical alphabets preserved, but the titular ethnicities now seemed to have been given clear dominance over the national minorities in their republics. The changing of Abkhazian place names to Georgianized ones had begun in 1936, and in 1937, again, at a time when Latin standards for minority languages all over the USSR were being converted to Cyrillic scripts, in the Georgian SSR the written Abkhaz language was converted from a Latin-based script to a Georgian-based one. In 1939 a mass resettling of Georgian peasants into Abkhazia began, part of the collectivization project of constructing large state farms for tobacco, tea, and citrus fruit, dramatically altering the demographic makeup of Abkhazia in favor of Georgians. Similarly, Georgians now dominated party and government positions....” (Blauvelt 2020: 201)

And between 1945 and 1953, Abkhaz-language primary education was also shifted to a Georgian-language format, triggering considerable resistance among ethnic Abkhaz and the seeds of future conflict². Specific policy enactments thus began to change the sociolinguistic context of Abkhaz language use: the medium of writing and instruction, the structure of state institutions, and even the linguistic demography of the region.

² Thus one leading author, Mikhail Lakerbai, then wrote: “As a writer, I am interested in strengthening the study of Abkhazian language and literature, but the things they are doing now, introducing Georgian language [in schools], bringing in Georgian cadres and others, are leading to the disappearance of Abkhazian language and literature, and of the Abkhaz altogether.” (Quoted in Blauvelt 2020: 205)

Probably the most frequent scenario for language shift is one in which many multiple variables are at play over long periods of time. Languages which in antiquity were widely and vigorously spoken may survive many vicissitudes of time but nonetheless decline over centuries, a phenomenon which the Caucasian Albanian language and its close descendant **Udi** perhaps best illustrate. From at least the early 5th century, after the advent of Christianity, it was one of the three largest language communities of the south Caucasus (alongside Georgian and Armenian), possessing its own indigenous alphabet and literature, and it was supported at the highest levels by the Albanian church and monarchy. Starting in the early 6th century and for the next thousand years, several profound institutional, demographic and sociolinguistic crises began to affect it:

- The abolition and annexation of the Kingdom of Albania after the reign of Vachagan III the Pious (r. 485–523) by the Sasanian Empire;
- The Plague of Justinian, which killed perhaps 30-50% of the population of the south Caucasus;
- Albania was the scene for some of the most intense warfare during the extremely destructive quarter-century conflict between the Byzantine and Sasanian Persian Empires, between 602 and 628;
- After the Arab conquest in the 7th century, ecclesiological disputes within the Albanian church between miaphysites in communion with the Armenian church and dyophysites in communion with Constantinople lead to the abolition of the autocephaly of the Albanian church in 705 and its subordination to the Armenian patriarchate; from this point, all evidence of Albanian writing and literature also ceases (Gippert et. al. 2008);
- From the middle of the 11th century, progressive in-migration of Oghuz Turkic-speaking tribes into the Kura-Araxes plain begins to alter the demographic balance of the region;
- On 30 September 1139, a catastrophic earthquake measuring approximately $\sim 7.7 M_{LH}$ occurs in and around the formerly Albanian city of Ganja, with at least 20,000 but perhaps as many as 200,000-300,000 deaths (Brosset 1851; Rayfield 2013; Berberian 2014);
- In 1220-1223, the Mongol invasion leads to the total destruction of Ganja, Barda, and Baylagan, cities which may have been home to numerous Albanian speakers;
- In 1346-1347, the bubonic plague reaches the Caucasus, killing perhaps one-third to one-half of the population of the south Caucasus (Rayfield 2013: 145; Benedictow 2004: 60);
- In 1614-1617, the Persian king Shah 'Abbas I devastates all Christian communities of eastern Georgia and northwestern Azerbaijan, killing perhaps between 60,000 and 100,000 Christians in the south Caucasus and deporting another 200,000 to Iran, in what was effectively an act of early-modern genocide (Blow 2014)

While many details of these events are unknown or difficult to discern, for purposes of understanding the external history of Caucasian Albanian and Udi languages, the broad outlines are clear that they must have had profound effects on language maintenance in the region: by undermining the demographic integrity of their communities; by engendering economic and social dislocation; by weakening the urban infrastructural basis of their geography; and by eroding the institutional and sociological supports that lend prestige to particular language varieties. By weakening the ethnic and

linguistic bonds that tied Albanian society together, these crises slowly lead to the disappearance or assimilation of Albanian speakers into neighboring Armenian, Azerbaijani, Georgian, Lezgi, Talysh and other ethnolinguistic groups of northwestern Azerbaijan. The fact that Georgian, Armenian and Azerbaijani speakers today number in the millions while Udi is spoken by around 5000 people surely speaks to a very different history of language maintenance, contact and identity in that community (see also Wier 2024a for further discussion of this case).

Thus in this instance and many other language communities in the Caucasus we see many of the criteria that contribute to language endangerment singled out by UNESCO in 2003 (Grenoble 2011: 38)

- a. Intergenerational transmission;
- b. Absolute number of speakers;
- c. Proportion of speakers within the total population;
- d. Trends in existing language domains;
- e. Response to new domains and media;
- f. Materials for language education and literacy;
- g. Governmental and institutional attitudes and policies, including official status and use;
- h. Community members' attitudes toward their own language, including issues of prestige and identity;
- i. Amount and quality of documentation

To which we might add the geospatial distribution of speakers within a specific socio-geographical context and culture.

§2 The role of multilingualism in language maintenance and language shift

2.1 Stable multilingualism

Language loss and language endangerment does not usually occur in a monolingual environment, as usually one or more other languages is present. Therefore, the possibility of language shift may occur, but endangerment is not merely the automatic or mechanical outcome of such contact; much depends on precisely how people in a given community react to the conditioning factors for maintenance in their sociolinguistic environment. The internal structure of communities may for example play an important role in determining how they interact with other linguistic communities. Most of the cultures of highland Daghestan for example are virilocally endogamous, in that men have traditionally taken wives from within their local community and only rarely from outside. When men exceptionally marry women from outside their community, the wife moves to live with her husband's community. Because of the high linguistic diversity in Daghestan, these rare cases of mixed marriages create a linguistic dilemma: do the wife and children produced by the marriage learn to speak the patrillect of their mother, that of their father, or both? As recently shown by Dobrushina (Dobrushina 2022), Daghestanian highland communities resolve this dilemma with a normative tradition that

women and children strictly learn the man's patrillect, irrespective of the speaker-size or economic importance of the woman's own patrillect:

"Several times I heard from Archis [who live in a single village – TRW] and from the residents of an adjacent Lak village that Archi is a *shaitan* (devil) language, because it is not spoken anywhere else. In spite of this huge difference in the status of the languages, the incoming Avar and Lak wives had to learn Archi and use it until the end of their lives." (Dobrushina 2022: 10)

As a result of this practice of strict virilocal endogamy, acquisition of a second language for women frequently occurs not in childhood but in early adulthood, after marriage, and becomes a totemic sign of the woman's shifted local identity. But it also has a more important consequence: it creates a fixed *stable* system of multilingualism in which outsiders are expected to learn the local language because "[w]e speak the language of the place the bread of which we eat" (Dobrushina 2022: 13).

Not all Caucasian societies are linguistically endogamous. In Georgia, traditional communities practiced a particularly rigorous form of exogamy in which marriage is notionally forbidden between couples with family contacts of seven generations or less (Tsimintia 2020: 1086; Tuite 2000). Consequently, mixed marriages between different language communities are far more common. And yet Georgia too has developed a different conventional system for maintaining stable multilingualism. It achieves this by rigid identification of speakers as in-group or out-group, and members of the out-group are always addressed with an out-group language, even when the out-group individual is perfectly capable of maintaining a conversation in the in-group language. Consider for example the following conversations I have witnessed:

(2) A: *Gamarjoba. Erti esp'resso tu šeidzleba.* [Hello. One espresso please.]

B: [Addressing A in English:] Here or take away?

A: *Ara, ak.* [No, here.]

B: Anything else?

A: *K'i, šok'oladis t'ort'i.* [Yes, a chocolate cake.]

B: With strawberry or raspberry?

A: *Marc'q'vit* [With raspberry]

B: Cash or card?

A: *Baratit* [By card]

B: Enjoy

A: *Madloba* [Thank you]

(3) Taxi driver: *Gamarjoba, kuda yedem?* [(In Georgian) Hello (switching to Russian) where are we going?]

Passenger: *v Rustavi* [in Russian: to Rustavi]

T: *K'argi, po-russki govoriš'?* [(In Georgian) *Good* (switching to Russian) do you speak Russian?]

P: *Da* (Russian: Yes)

T: *Nu davai togda na russkom govoriš', čto-by ty ne mučalsya* [(In Russian): Well, then let's speak Russian so that you don't suffer]

P: *Ya znayu yazyk, ya mestny, tut rodilsya* [(In Russian) I know the language, I'm local, I was born here]

T: *Davai, na russkom, v obšem vižu že čto trudno tebe* [Let's go in Russian, I see that [speaking Georgian] is difficult for you]

P: *Davai* [Let's go]

These dialogues are remarkable in a number of ways. In the first dialogue, the out-group customer approaches a café cashier and proceeds to make an order in Georgian – to which the cashier responds immediately in English. The customer continues to respond to each question in perfect Georgian, always receiving a response in English, even though the cashier herself is Georgian and the transaction is occurring in Georgia. In the second dialogue, the language negotiation becomes explicit: the in-group speaker (a taxi-driver) explicitly asks the out-group passenger what language he prefers, and even when the passenger makes explicit that he is a native speaker in the language, the taxi driver persists in defining his out-group status as 'difficult'. Thus, unlike Daghestan, where linguistic community boundaries are policed by a major life-event and residence in a particular locality, in Georgia group boundaries are policed by flouting the Gricean pragmatic norm that an interlocutor chooses to speak in a particular language because he or she is perfectly competent in it. While it might strike inhabitants of major metropolitan areas of the West as unusual, where there is always the expectation to speak the metropolitan language, such language policing is one way that communities sustain the usage of the languages associated with their identities: strictly outsider languages with outsiders, and insider languages with insiders.

2.2 Code-switching and language-shift

Such scenarios show how complicated language contact scenarios can often be, when coupled with other nonlinguistic kinds of identity negotiation. In practice, contact rarely involves a discrete choice between language A and language B. In endangered language communities especially, various kinds of code-switching can occur between an endangered language and one or more contact languages. Consider the following linguistically quite remarkable and complex conversation recorded by Gippert et al. (2004: 32) in Vartashen dialect of Udi, spoken in the village of Zinobiani, Georgia. Here

VARTASHEN UDI TEXT	ENGLISH TRANSLATION
ani- <i>a k'ak' k'acria ra k'ak' ai k'ak' st'rogi</i> ani očen st'rogi Yesli k't'o-t'o <i>ai</i> vot' devuš'k'a xat'eli by- šint'e but'uxsa t'e xinär aifestağo sa lašk'ona geräg tağan lašk'ona čičaq'un xinära <i>sadğac</i> <u>eve</u> <u>ŭq'ak'usunaxun</u> aitq'unexa <i>ho</i> xinärena oša bip'ta eisa to k'ua q'at'o išq'armux <i>xo da</i> heq'unbesa aitq'unexa tuda-suda iräziq'unbaksa oša nišane eisa nišan <i>k'argi</i> mia <i>exla rogor ai nišani</i> a ğarenesa <i>da teli ma(gida)</i> stol q'aiq'unexa q'ai <i>supra q'velaperi ra</i>	They (are) also... so strong right? how... look, how strict they are, very strict. If someone like wanted a girl, if he wants to marry the girl, he must go to the wedding. For the wedding they look for a girl <i>from wherever, they go together into the house</i>, they speak, like about the girl, <i>hm</i> They go by fours into the house, among them men, <i>right and</i> tie the knot, speak (with one another about) this and that, enjoy each other... Then comes the engagement. The engagement, <i>good now here, now like the engagement...</i> So the groom comes, <i>and</i> they offer her <i>a whole table, a table, a banquet (with) everything right?</i>

Table 4. Code-switching in Vartashen Udi (adapted from Gippert 2004: 32)

a speaker of Nij-dialect, originally from that village in Azerbaijan, discusses engagement practices in Zinobiani village, code-switching from Russian (bold), Georgian (italic), Vartashen dialect of Udi, Azeri (single underline), and Nij-dialect of Udi (double underline) within just a few lines (see Table 4).

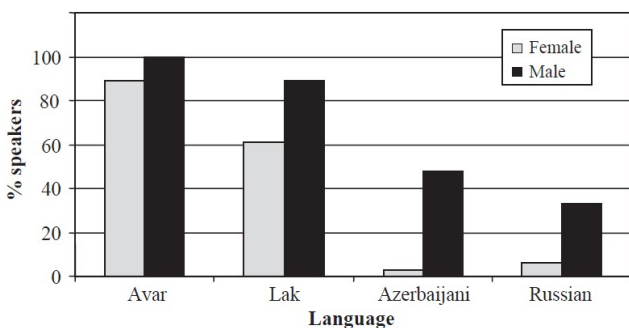
The speaker begins the narrative in Russian, interspersed with Georgian tag words and hesitation phenomena, then switches to Vartashen Udi to discuss what conditions are necessary for the marriage – but because the speaker is actually from Nij and not Vartashen also engages in *interdialectal* code-switching between Vartashen and (linguistically quite different) Nij dialect and also some Azerbaijani, again interspersing the entire discourse with Georgian particles. As O'Shannessy notes, this kind of highly complex code-switching behavior is typical of small communities under intense pressure to shift: 'In situations of intense cultural pressure to shift, and where code-switching between languages is a typical way of speaking, a new bilingual mixed language may result from conventionalization of code-switching practices' (O'Shannessy XX: 86), and she comments: 'These languages are not created to enable communication with speakers of other languages, but for communication within the group that developed them'. While the above discourse is probably not yet best described as a mixed language, this general situation seems to be a good description of what is happening in Zinobiani, where all speakers

are now above the age of about 40, and where the presence of prestige state languages Russian and Georgian is omnipresent in the mass media.

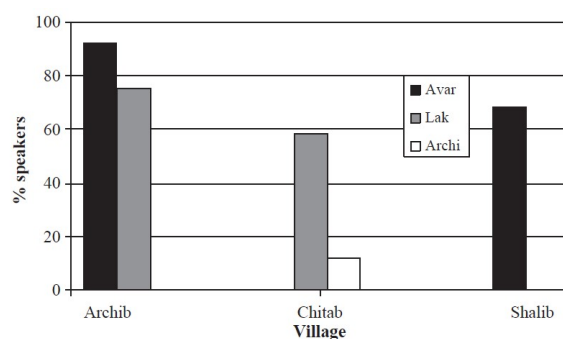
2.3 Loss of multilingual domains and cultures of multilingualism

But what happens when the linguistic practice under threat is not so much the internal language of a community itself as the external contact languages that such a community uses to interface with the outside world? This is a common hallmark of shifting sociolinguistic environments which bring about the incipient steps of language endangerment. In a recent series of papers documenting the *Atlas of Multilingualism in Dagestan* (Dobrushina 2013; Dobrushina et al. 2019), Nina Dobrushina and colleagues have demonstrated that over the last century Daghestan has undergone a radical intergenerational shift in the usage and distribution of L2 languages spoken by people across the region. By interviewing members of the language communities about their own language competence as well as their immediate ancestors and family, they have begun to build up a statistical profile of which Daghestanian languages have been used in the recent past as local *lingua francas* within particular parts of Daghestan compared to today.

What they have found is that acquisition of L2 varieties depended on many multiple variables, including year of birth, years of schooling, levels of literacy, how near or far a settlement with a differing L1 was, what functions the L2 served in the local community, whether men or women were acquiring the language, and local attitudes towards the adjacent villages. Dobrushina (2013) studied the history of multilingualism between the highland villages of Archib (the sole village complex where the Archi language is spoken), Chitab (where Avar is spoken) and Shalib (where Lak is spoken). While in Archib around 60-80% of both men and women born before 1919 acquired both Avar and Lak, competence in more distant languages like Azerbaijani and Russian was far less common, and far more dependent on gender, generally with only men acquiring such languages. This is because generally only men travelled far from the native village for work. She notes that the situation today is quite different: ‘Today, the young Archis communicate with their Lak neighbors in Russian, but in Avar with their Avar neighbors. Some interviewees, however, indicate that modern youth speak Avar less fluently than the older generation; if this claim is true, this is an indication of a further reduction in local multilingualism’ (Dobrushina 2013: 391).



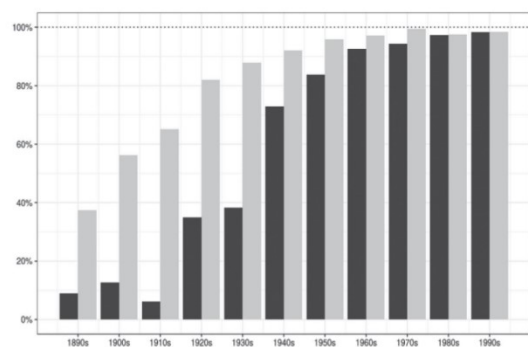
Competence and gender asymmetry in multilingualism of Archis born before 1919 (Dobrushina 2013: 385)



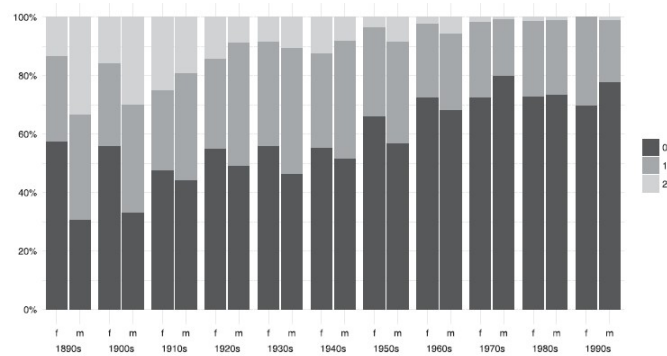
Percentage of neighbor multilingualism among people born before 1919 (Dobrushina 2013: 387)

Table 5: Patterns of multilingualism in Archib, Chitab and Shalib of people born before 1919.

What has subsequently occurred in generations born after 1919 was effectively a wholesale switch in L2 acquisition practices, for the most part towards Russian. This can only partly be explained by the introduction of systems of mass education in Daghestan after ca. 1930; it also reflects changing patterns of migration and urbanization. Whereas before the 20th century trade and migration networks often involved moving seasonally downwards towards better acreage and land for grazing or towards local market towns which had one dominant language (e.g. Archis moving toward Kumukh, where Avar is the dominant language; see §1.2 above), in the 20th century, migration frequently went much further to major cities such as Makhachkala where no one ethnicity dominated and where Russian was already a major lingua franca. As Dobrushina says, ‘in the second half of the 20th century Daghestan acquired what it never had before – a common lingua franca. Russian is only one of the fourteen official languages of Daghestan, but its actual status is exceptional. Its channels of spread were schools, radio and TV broadcasts, higher education and compulsory military service. In the villages, Russian is usually an L2, but in the cities the number of young Daghestanians monolingual in Russian constantly grows’ (Dobrushina 2013: 390). This is not just reflected in generational shifts that we see towards Russian, but also a convergence of the linguistic competence in that language between genders:



Knowledge of Russian among men and women in Daghestan for the whole time period (Dobrushina et al. 2018: 13)



Knowledge of neighboring languages in Daghestan among men and women for the whole period (Dobrushina et al. 2018: 14)

Table 6. Decline of competence among both men and women in neighboring L2s and rise of competence in Russian

The loss of this complex system of multilingualism has thus been a prelude to the overall endangerment of linguistic diversity in the region as a whole.

§3 Structural Aspects of Endangered Languages of the Caucasus

The Caucasus is also a typological epicenter of linguistic rarities, and because of this many of its endangered languages also manifest traits that are found rarely or not at all elsewhere. As a consequence, their fate has implications for linguists’ understanding of what a possible language is. In Wier (2024b), I summarize over four dozen different rare typological traits found in Caucasian languages, including rare categories, rare numbers of subcategories, the absence of common categories, rare combinations of categories, along with rare

Phonetics & Phonology	Morphology	Syntax & Alignment
Pharyngealized and labiovelarized consonants (across Abkhaz-Adyghean and Nakh-Daghestanian)	Gender systems with between four and eight gender categories (Batsbi)	Hierarchical alignment (Lak and many varieties of Dargwa)
Ejective fricatives (in Kabardian, Abaza and Ubykh)	A single pronoun to express both 1PL inclusive & 2PL (Itsari & Shari Dargwa)	Adverbs, particles, postpositions and even personal pronouns as targets of agreement (in many Nakh-Daghestanian languages)
Glottalized lateral affricates (in Avar and Hunzib)	Endoclititics (Udi)	Multiple coexisting case-assignment systems (across Kartvelian)
Palatalized uvulars (Abaza & Ubykh)	Mesoclititics (Lak)	Violation of the Coordinate Structure Constraint (Tanti Dargwa)
Multiple secondary articulations (e.g. [q ^{sw}] in Ubykh)	Frequent circumfixes (across Kartvelian)	<i>Suffixaufnahme</i> , agreement of possessors with possessum in case and number features (in some Kartvelian languages and dialects)
Velar lateral obstruents (Archi)	Morphological blocking in verb agreement (across Kartvelian)	Backward raising constructions in Adyghe
Final voicing (Lezgian)	Recursive valence-increasing processes (in Abkhaz-Adyghean languages)	Agreement for gender and number but not person (in most Nakh-Daghestanian languages)
Syllabically heavy onsets (Tsakhur)	Basic nonderived verbs forming a closed class (in Archi, Udi and Ingush)	Stative-active ('split-S') case assignment (in Georgian and Svan)

Table 7. Typological rarities among Caucasian languages (Wier 2024b)

phonological, morphological or syntactic construction types that such categories manifest or manipulate (a sample of which are found in **Table 7**).

In some cases, these rarities are found in just one or two languages, while in others they found extensively across the region and across family lines. Thus labiovelarized and pharyngealized consonants, the absence of valence-decreasing processes, and non-nominative alignments generally are found broadly across the north Caucasus, while velar lateral fricatives and affricates such as [kɪ^w] are found in just Archi, ejective fricatives such as [ɬ] in just Kabardian, Abaza and Ubykh, and endoclititics in just Udi. We can thus speak not only of different levels of *language* endangerment, but also different levels of endangerment of *typological features*.

It is worth reflecting on this fact because some of these features are rare even in a region replete with rarities, and in some cases are truly unique. Thus the Archi phoneme inventory (as in **Table 8**) includes around 26 vowel phonemes and between 74 and 82 consonant phonemes,

	LABIAL	DENTAL PLAIN	LAB.	ALVEOLAR PLAIN	LAB.	PALATAL	VELAR PLAIN	LAB.	UVULAR PLAIN	LAB.	PHAR.	PHAR-LAB.	EPIG.	GLOTTAL
PLOS	p, pʰ	t, tʰ	tʷ				k	kʷ	q	qʷ	qˢ	qˢʷ		
	b	d	dʷ				g	gʷ						
	pʼ	tʼ					kʼ	kʷʼ	qʼ, qˢʼ	qʷʼ	qˢ, qˢʼ	qˢʷʼ	ʔ	ʔ
AFFR	m	n												
		tʰ, tʰˢ	tʰʷ	tʃ	tʃʷ		kˡ	kˡʷ						
		tʰˢʼ, tʰˢˢʼ	tʰʷ	tʃʰ, tʃʰˢʼ	tʃʰʷʼ		kˡʼ	kˡʷʼ						
FRIC		s, sˢ	sʷ, sʷˢ	ʃ, ʃˢ	ʃʷ, ʃʷˢ		ɬ, ɬˢ	ɬʷ, ɬʷˢ	χ, χˢ	χʷ, χʷˢ	χˢ	χˢʷ, χˢʷˢ	h	h
		z	zʷ	ʒ	ʒʷ		ɮ		ʁ	ʁʷ	ʁˢ	ʁˢʷ		
Trill		r												
Appr		l				j		w						

Table 8. Archi consonant phoneme inventory (Chumakina et al. 2007)

among the largest inventories of all languages. *Rarissima* like [kˡʷʼ], [qˢʷʼ], and [χˢʷˢ] are possible in part because the language makes extremely liberal use of secondary articulations of labialization, pharyngealization, and glottalization across different places and manners of articulation (in itself, a rarity), in addition to fortis/lenis distinctions, and these are by no means mutually exclusive. Languages without these (themselves rare) kinds of secondary articulation simply would not satisfy the preconditions necessary to have them in their phonemic inventory.³

In some cases, endangered rare features arise not as the synchronic overlapping of rare features as in Archi, but rather as rare diachronic evolutionary pathways. One such construction is the endoclititicizing system of Udi person markers. Unlike most Nakh-Daghestanian languages whose verbs agree for gender and number but not person, Udi has lost its inherited genders and innovated a set of person agreement markers. These however do not stay affixed to a given position on the verb as in (4a), but instead may attach to other elements of the clause such as negators(4b) and focal items (4c), as mesoclitics between a verb root and a light-verb stem (4d) and even as endoclititics inside otherwise inseparable verb roots (4e).

(4) Distribution of Udi person markers

- a. qʼačəğ-ğ-on bez tängin-ax bašqʼ-al=**qʼun** (Harris 2002: 117)
 thief-PL-ERG my money-DAT steal-FUT.II=**3PL**
 ‘Thieves will steal my money.’
- b. nana-n te=**ne** buʳğə-b-e pʼaˢ ačikʼalšey (Harris 2002: 117)
 mother-ERG not=3SG find-LV-AOR.II two toy.ABS
 ‘Mother did not find two toys.’
- c. qʼačəğ-ğ-on bez tängin-ax=**qʼun** bašqʼ-e (Harris 2002: 119)
 thief-PL-ERG my money-DAT=**3PL** steal-AOR.II
 ‘Thieves stole *my money*.’

³ According to the World Atlas of Language Structures, only 16% of languages have ejective consonants; around ~8% have labiovelars; and around ~4% have pharyngeals.

- d. nana-n bu^ʕga-*ne*-b-e p'a^ʕ ačik'alšey (Harris 2002: 122)
 mother-ERG find-3SG-LV-AOR.II two toy.ABS
 'Mother found two toys.'
- e. q'ačag-ğ-on bez tängin-ax baš<q'un>q'-e (Harris 2002: 122)
 thief-PL-ERG my money-DAT steal<3PL>-AOR.II
 'Thieves stole my money.'

What, if anything, constrains the placement of these markers? As discussed at some length in Harris (2002), some tenses obligatorily take suffixal person markers, while in others they attach to discourse or logical structural properties of the clause, and the markers show up as mesoclitics or endoclititics only as a last resort. This complicated system, Harris explains, only makes sense as the result of multiple different episodes of grammaticalization of 'trapped' morphology in which person markers become trapped between an incorporated noun/verb root and a light verb (resulting in mesoclititics), which then are reinterpreted by extension to verbal roots which never historically had such light verbs (resulting in endoclititics).

A different kind of typologically rare feature can be found in **Megrelian** (Zan; Kartvelian). This language features a complicated system of case assignment in which different tense-aspect combinations feature different arrays of case assignment for subject, object and indirect object (Harris 1992). Thus in the transitive verb in (5), present-future series verbs assign nominative case (*-i/null*) to their subject, and dative case (*-s*) to their direct and indirect objects. In the aorist series of verbs used to narrative past events however, the subject is marked with narrative case (*-k*), the direct object with nominative case, and the indirect object with dative case. In the evidential perfect series used to make assertions based on deduced evidence, the subject is now again in the dative, the direct object in the nominative and the indirect object in the allative case.

- (5) a. Present-future series, ditransitive: [NOM_{AG} ~ DAT_{REC} ~ DAT_{TH}] (Harris 1985: 55-56)
 Muma a-rdz-en-s cxen-s skua-s
 father.NOM PRV-give-TH-3SG horse-DAT child-DAT
 'Father is giving the child a horse.'
- b. Aorist series, ditransitive: [NARR_{AG} ~ DAT_{REC} ~ NOM_{TH}]
 Muma-k ki-me-č-u cxen-i skua-s
 father-NARR PVB-PVB-give.AOR-AOR.3SG horse-NOM child-DAT
 'Father gave the child a horse.'
- c. Evidential perfect series, ditransitive: [DAT_{AG} ~ ALL_{REC} ~ NOM_{TH}]
 Muma-s ki-me-u-č-am-u cxen-i skua-ša
 father-DAT PVB-PVB-PRV-give-TH-AOR.3SG horse-NOM child-ALL
 'Father has apparently given the child a horse.'

- (6) a. Present series, active/agentive intransitive: [NOM_{AG}]
 dzğabi (teli dğa-s) sxap-un-s
 girl.NOM (all day-DAT) dance-TH-3SG
 'The girl is dancing all day.'
- b. Aorist series, active/agentive intransitive: [NARR_{AG}]
 dzğabi-k (ko)-sxap-u
 girl-NARR PVB-dance-AOR.3SG
 'The girl danced.'
- c. Evidential Perfect series, active/agentive intransitive: [DAT_{TH}]
 dzğabi-s (ko)-u-sxap-u
 girl-DAT PVB-PRV-dance-AOR.3SG
 'The girl has apparently danced.'
- (7) a. Present series, stative intransitive: [NOM_{TH}]
 k'oč-i ğur-u
 man-NOM die-3SG.INTR
 'The man dies.'
- b. Aorist series, stative intransitive: [NARR_{TH}]
 k'oč-k do-ğur-u
 man-NARR PVB-die-3SG.INTR
 'The man died.'
- c. Evidential Perfect series, stative intransitive: [NOM_{TH}]
 k'oč-i do-u-ğur-u
 man-NOM PVB-PRV-die-3SG.INTR
 'The man has apparently died.'

Noteworthy in this system is the use of two distinct case suffixes, the nominative *-i* and the narrative *-k* which (except for dative-affective constructions) marks subjects across different verb classes in the first two series. Thus, while in the present-future and aorist series there is not an actual change of subject alignment, the case marking is nonetheless an implicit marker of tense.

When we widen our examination to intransitive predicates, we see that things are yet more complicated. The first two series behave like transitives, but in the evidential perfect, dative *-s* now marks the subjects of transitives and agentive/active intransitives as in (6), while stative intransitives in (7) are marked with nominative case *-i*. As one can see in Table 9, Megrelian thus has a noncanonical kind of nominative-accusative alignment in the first two tense-aspect series in which case implicitly flags tense, while in the third tense-aspect series we find a split-intransitive system, similar to but distinct from the Split-S systems found in Georgian and Svan.

	(Di)transitive	Active Intr.	Stative Intr.	Dative-Affective
<i>PRESENT-FUTURE</i>	SUBJ: NOM IOBJ: DAT DOBJ: DAT	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: DAT DOBJ: NOM
<i>AORIST</i>	SUBJ: NARR IOBJ: DAT DOBJ: NOM	SUBJ: NARR	SUBJ: NARR	SUBJ: DAT DOBJ: NOM
<i>PERFECT- EVIDENTIAL</i>	SUBJ: DAT IOBJ: ALL DOBJ: NOM	SUBJ: DAT	SUBJ: NOM	SUBJ: DAT DOBJ: NOM

Table 9. Megrelian case-assignment arrays across different tense-aspect series.

Such structural rarities may become endangered or disappear when the languages in which they are spoken cease to be spoken entirely. However, even in cases where the languages themselves do not become dormant, the features of those languages may do so. In such cases, languages experiencing pressure to shift or even obsolescence may undergo sometimes radical structural changes as speakers begin to lose registers or domains of usage. Depending on the level and nature of contact, this can extend from relatively casual lexical borrowing to more intense structural borrowing of function words to heavy structural borrowing of basic case and agreement patterns (following Thomason 2001). An example of relatively heavy borrowing can be found in **Batsbi**, a.k.a Tsova-Tush (Nakh; Nakh-Daghestanian). This language has not only borrowed thousands of Georgian words (around 44% of Batsbi lexicon has been borrowed, the vast majority from or through Georgian (Wichers-Schreur 2021)), its system of case-agreement has also shifted from the more ergative alignment found in other Nakh languages to a Fluid-S split-intransitive system similar to dominant Georgian. These borrowings are often nativized to fit the system of incorporating light verbs found in Batsbi. Thus a Georgian verb like *angarišeba* ‘to count, calculate’ is borrowed with the adverbial case (-*ad*) of the Georgian verbal noun incorporated into the Batsbi light-verb -*ar*:

- (4) oqus t’ateb aygršebad-d-Ø-o (Kadagidze & Kadagidze 1984)
DIST.ERG money.ABS count-GEND.AGR-TR-NPST
‘He counts money’

(Here the word for money or silver, *t’ateb*, bears one of Batsbi’s five productive genders, and -*d* is the gender-number agreement on the verb reflecting that.) There are other kinds of less obvious structural influences too. When Batsbi speakers count year dates, they only use Batsbi numerals for year and decade numerals, while for higher numerals denoting centuries and millennia, they use Georgian numerals: *atas cxraas* (< Georgian ‘one thousand nine hundred’) *tqā vorl šare* (< Batsbi ‘twenty sevenyear.LOC’) “in the year 1927”. Thus to speak Batsbi fluently in

some instances indirectly *requires* knowledge of some Georgian; there is simply no other natural way to articulate this construction.

In the more intense levels of language contact, the syntax and morphology may also be affected or even effectively remodeled on particular, more dominant languages:

- Older generations of Iron Ossetian typically use SOV word-order, while younger generations are more likely to use SVO typical of Russian (Erschler 2021a);
- Older generations of Iron Ossetian often do not express personal pronouns, while this is less typical of younger generations exposed to Russian, a non-pro-drop language (Erschler 2021a);
- Older speakers of Adyghe and Kabardian generally find sluicing ellipsis ungrammatical, while younger speakers exposed to Russian are more likely to accept such constructions (Erschler 2021b)
- Older speakers of Urum may mark possessive noun phrases with double marking, genitive on the possessor and agreement on the possessum, as in standard Turkish, while younger speakers are more likely to use only genitival marking, as in Russian and Georgian (Neugebauer 2016).

However, obsolescence and other forms of intense language contact do not always result in shift towards the structural pattern of one single dominant language. In **Hinuq** (Tsezic; Nakh-Daghestanian), different kinds of features of the language of older generations seem to be changing because of contact with several different other, more dominant contact languages (Forker 2019).

According to Forker, many of these changes are relatively recent changes visible within still living generations of speakers. For example, young people do not produce front rounded vowels at all, even though very old speakers above the age of about 60 still do. This reflects the pattern of more dominant contact languages like Avar, Tsez and Russian, all languages which lack front rounded vowels. Another feature that varies by generation is labialization, younger

	Georgian	Tsez, Bezhta	Avar	Russian
Phonology		loss of front rounded vowels		ongoing loss of labialization
Morphology		distributive suffix –t’a	derivational suffixes, enclitics	
Syntax		comparative construction	clause conjunction	clause conjunction, constituent order
Lexicon	a few loanwords		massive borrowing: nouns, adjectives, adverbs, verbal infinitives, etc.	massive borrowing of nouns, particles, adjectives, infinitives

Table 10. Influence of Georgian, Tsez, Bezhta, Avar and Russian on Hinuq grammar (adapted from Forker 2019)

speakers are also less likely to articulate labialization on consonants as conservative speakers do (8) and more likely to shift that feature to the adjacent vowels, as in (9). Forker notes: ‘When testing young speakers for this feature, it happened several times that the speakers corrected their pronunciation from non-labialized to labialized, particularly when older speakers were present during the recordings’ (Forker 2019: 6).

(8) Conservative Hinuq labialization distinguishing different nominal stems

	absolutive stem	oblique stem	translation
a.	rek ^w ɛ	rek ^w u-	‘man’
b.	šeg ^w ɛ	šoge-	‘mare’
c.	q ^w ono	q ^w ɛna-	‘two’

(9) Hinuq nominal stems with labialization and with labialization-loss

	labialized stem	labialization-loss	
a.	x ^w in	xun	‘mountain’
b.	ɣ ^w ero	ɣore	‘cow’
c.	ɣ ^w ede	ɣode	‘day’
d.	rek ^w ɛ	rek ^w ɛ / rek ^w u	‘man’
e.	λex ^w ɛ-s	λoxe-s / λexe-s	‘remain-PST’

§4 Conclusion

The Caucasus remains one of the world's most linguistically diverse regions, but this diversity now stands at a critical juncture. This paper has shown that language endangerment in the region is the result of a complex interplay of geographic, historical, sociopolitical, and typological factors. While the Caucasus has long functioned as a classical residual zone that preserved linguistic heterogeneity, the forces of modernity—state centralization, mass education, media saturation, and urban migration—have disrupted traditional language ecologies and intensified language shift.

Across the region, different mechanisms of endangerment are at work. Violent upheavals and coerced migrations have fractured communities and hastened language loss. Deep-rooted patterns of seasonal migration and social stratification, such as vertical polylingualism, have long shaped language contact hierarchies and now accelerate asymmetrical language replacement. State policy and ideology, from antiquity to today, have left lasting legacies, either by actively suppressing minority languages or co-opting them into administrative frameworks that privileged larger, more institutionally embedded tongues. Even where stable multilingualism persists, as in parts of Daghestan or Georgia, the cultural norms that sustain it are increasingly under pressure, resulting in the erosion of multilingual competencies and the collapse of long-standing patterns of linguistic exchange.

Endangerment in the Caucasus is not only a matter of speaker numbers, but also of structural and typological richness. The region hosts some of the world's rarest linguistic features—phonological, morphological, and syntactic—that are themselves at risk, whether through language death or structural attrition under contact pressure. As languages like Archi, Udi, Batsbi, and Hinuq lose speakers or shift domains of usage, they may also lose the features

that make them typologically exceptional and theoretically invaluable to our understanding of linguistic possibility.

The future of Caucasian languages therefore hinges not just on documentation or institutional support, but on broader questions of community identity, intergenerational continuity, and the reshaping of multilingual ideologies in the 21st century. What is at stake is not merely a catalog of endangered tongues, but a window into the human capacity for linguistic innovation, resilience, and adaptation in one of the most linguistically fertile corners of the world.

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